ACTIVITY 12

Divide into groups. Look again at Emily's story in **5**. Each group should prepare to re-tell the story, using one or more subversions. Change the original version so that the narrative no longer follows the same path. The following suggestions may help you:

- Flashback – start the story from the moment when Emily is facing the dragon.
- Flashforward – begin the story with a dream sequence in which Emily faces a fire-breathing beast.
- Twist – Emily does not have to be human!
- Parallel narratives – tell Emily's story side by side with Prince Matthew's (or the dragon's) story. This could make the audience feel differently towards them.

Audience positioning

Audiences enjoy texts most when they are really involved in them. When you analyse a media text such as a film, identify the key techniques that 'sew' the audience into it. When they are genuinely hooked into the text's narrative and development, it is as if they actually have their own position in it. You can see why this is so important – someone who is really involved in a text is much less likely to switch it off or put it back on the shelf. Here are some techniques that help an audience to become involved or positioned in a film or television text.

- **Point-of-view shots** – the camera adopts the position of a character within the text. This can be an over-the-shoulder shot, looking at whatever the character is looking at, or a shot from the point of view of the character. This is particularly powerful when the character is experiencing a strong emotion – the viewer is more likely to feel their emotion when taking their point of view.
- **Reaction shots** – the camera moves to an extreme close-up of a character's face to show their reaction to something that has happened (see **6**: Eddie Murphy in *The Nutty Professor* (1996)).



6 Reading facial expression is crucial to understanding a character's reaction

- **Insert shots** – this technique gives the audience extra or privileged information that one or more characters may not yet know, for example in a two-set scene with two characters in different locations. The audience knows what is happening to each of them when the characters themselves do not.
- **Shot reverse shot** – the camera alternates between two characters to show their building relationship (whether positive or negative), often as a conversation is taking place between them. This is a very common technique in dramas where the inter-relationship between characters is very important. The camera acts as a third person in shot reverse shot, giving the audience the impression that they are turning their heads from one character to the other.



7 These three images demonstrate the shot reverse shot technique

ACTIVITY 13

1 Watch a series of film clips from different genres. Identify as many techniques of audience positioning as possible.

2 Using a still camera, create a series of shots which demonstrate each of the audience positioning techniques. Display them in your classroom with an imaginary narrative situation written underneath each one. You can see an example in **7**.

Additional camera terms and definitions



A great deal of time is spent on setting up every scene in a film. It is important to position the cameras in just the right way to capture on film exactly what the director wants the audience to see. In addition to the techniques mentioned already, here are some other camera shots that you will be able to identify in the films you study.

Camera term	What it means
Establishing shot	The camera is set far back to show or to emphasise setting or location rather than the subject
Slo-mo	A moment which is replayed very slowly
Pan shot	The camera moves horizontally, taking in all the details along the way
Tracking shot	The camera moves alongside characters either using a hand-held technique or smooth dolly tracks
Zoom	The camera focuses in on, or out from, a subject by using a telephoto lens
Mini cam	A tiny camera is placed in an unusual place for effect
Steadi-cam	A weighted camera is strapped to an operator to allow hand-held but controlled movement

TIP

Using a chart or table to present textual analysis will help you to keep under the word limit.

ACTIVITY 14 EXTENSION

Watch the first ten minutes of one of these films: *Star Wars IV: A New Hope* (1997), *The Truman Show* (1998) or *Saving Private Ryan* (1998). Look for evidence of genre characteristics, narrative structure, audience positioning and carefully set up camerawork. Present your findings as a table, chart, report or essay.

Intertextuality

Have you ever experienced the thrill of watching a film and recognising a reference to another film? This type of link between two texts is known as an **intertextual reference**. Do you recognise the phrases 'I'll be back' and 'shaken not stirred'? Where have you heard them? Can you think of other phrases which you have heard used intertextually in films or TV programmes?

Intertextual references can be visual as well. You can find a good example of this in *Toy Story 2* (1999). The toys are riding around Al's Toy Barn in a Barbie Tour guide car and Rex the dinosaur is running behind them, his reflection clearly seen in the wing mirror. This is an intertextual reference to the scene in *Jurassic Park* (1993) when the T-Rex can be seen in the wing mirror chasing the tour guide vehicle – in this case, with the intention of eating the passengers!

Another example is the Robin Hood scene in *Shrek* (2000) when Princess Fiona fights Robin Hood and his men; she fights in the same style as Trinity from *The Matrix* (1999).

The story of *Bridget Jones Diary* (2001) is full of intertextual references to Jane Austin's *Pride and Prejudice*, although the settings and the characters of the heroines could hardly be more different. The basic storyline is similar: girl meets and hates boy but after many mishaps realises his true worth and marries him. Among other references,

KEY TERM

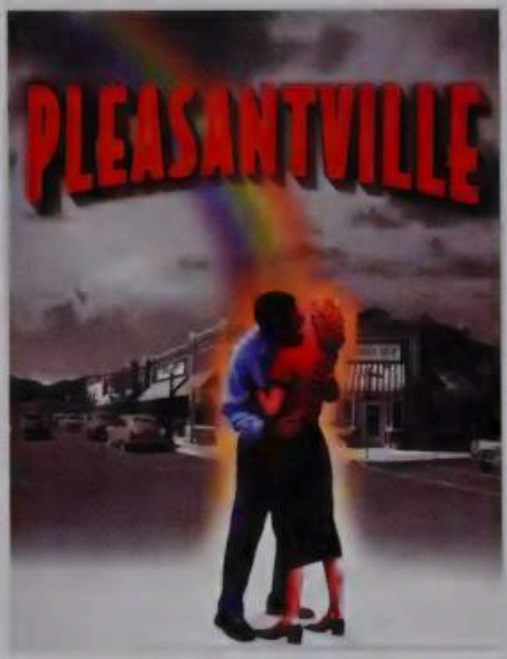
Intertextual reference when one media text mimics or refers to another media text in a way that many consumers will recognise

the hero's surname is Darcy in both stories. In case anyone missed the point, Colin Firth, who had played Mr Darcy in the 1995 BBC mini-series of *Pride and Prejudice*, was cast as Mark Darcy in the film.

How films are promoted: film posters

Film posters: giving information

Film posters are hard to ignore – they are large, they are eye-catching and they are often intriguing. How well do they communicate information about the genre, characters and events in the films? Look at posters **8** to **11**, showing films featuring movie star Reese Witherspoon. What genre would you expect each film to be? In what different ways is Reese Witherspoon presented in these posters?



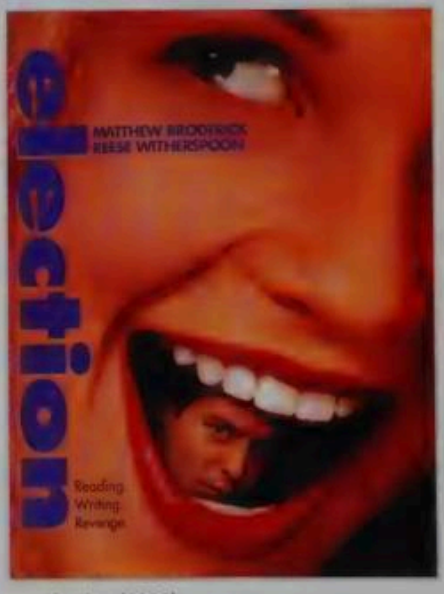
8 *Pleasantville* (1998)



9 *The Importance of Being Earnest* (2002)



10 *Fear* (1996)



11 *Election* (1999)